

Catechetical Letter: The Four Bows

The following is a significantly edited transcription of a short homily: http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/orthopraxis_2010+the-four-bows.mp3

The Holy Fathers call prayer the "science of sciences." Prayer is a cooperative venture between man and God. Only God can purify the soul, but man must order his life in such a way that he is prepared for God to enter the soul. Therefore it is impossible to pray without effort, and living our life spiritually, and fighting sin, and establishing a rule of prayer. The Apostle Paul tells us to "pray without ceasing," but most of us know that we do not come even close to this. The person who prays without ceasing does not need to prepare himself for prayer since he is always praying. ***We must prepare ourselves for prayer.***

The four bows" is a way to prepare ourselves for prayer, and if we are honest with ourselves, it is sometimes the only prayer that we might say in any formal way in the morning.

The four bows were originally an article in a publication called Nicodemus. This article was the teaching of a bishop who would teach children how to pray, and it applies to us. It applies to us is, if we are honest with ourselves, we would know that we often do not pray as we should, and we often allow things to get in the way of prayer. Whether it be oversleeping or something we have to do before we have to go to work or laziness or just the hustle of the day, we don't say our morning prayers at all, or we don't say them completely, or we don't say them with attention. Generally, if you don't pray in the morning, the day doesn't go as well as it could.

This applies to all of us because it is something simple that takes less than a minute. It doesn't take a book. It just takes a little bit of time and focus.

Before anything else, when you get up in the morning, before brushing your teeth or getting a drink of water, do the "Four Bows." Stand by your icon corner (you should have an icon corner or an icon or an icon or two in someplace that is easy to get to) or a cross on the wall, and do four bows or *poklans* (that is the Russian word for "bow").

A bow is when you make the sign of the cross and as you do this, bow deeply, with your hand touching or coming close to the ground. You could also do a prostration. A prostration is: as you make the sign of the cross prostrate to the ground (get on your knees and bring your head on or close to the ground) and come back up. Either one is acceptable. I recommend that you try to do prostrations because they warm up the body and the soul, and they help keep us from being lazy, but if you're "creaky" in the morning, at least do the bows. Each bow (prostration) is for a particular prayer.

"Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner."

"Most Holy Theotokos, save us."

"St. Seraphim pray to God for me." (put the name of your patron saint here, or any favorite saint)

"Holy Angel of God, my guardian, pray unto God for me."

This is the perfect time to begin the rest of your prayers, but, things as they are, you might have something to do, you might have to wake up the kids or whatever, but at least, if you do not go back to your prayers in the morning, you have at least begun the day giving your first fruits to God.

You could, if you're zealous, do more bows because you have many favorite saints who you want to pray to, or you may want to do a prostration or a bow for each person in your family and people very close to you (highly recommended!).

This very small rule is an application of a fundamental principle that I want you to tattoo on your forehead and look at it whenever you are lazy or despondent or feeling inadequate because you just don't do enough. **"It is better to do a little thing then *not* do a big thing."**

Let this be your small rule for the beginning, and then, if you pray more later, that is good. But if your day takes on a life of its own, as our days often do, then at least you will have offered a prayer to God in the beginning. So let it be just four bows, and then if you say your morning rule, fine, but if you make it into ten bows or twelve bows or 50 bows, there will be many days when you'll think, "Oh, I just can't do 50 bows," and you won't do it at all. But you can do four bows. It doesn't take long at all, maybe 30 seconds. Please, begin saying the "Four Bows" when you get up in the morning.

This is perfect for children because they love things that involve motion and activity. When they get up, say, "Let's do the four bows together," and TEACH (by EXAMPLE) your children to give the first part of their day, the best part of their day, to God. every day

Priest Seraphim Holland

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